The awards—presented by the Tourism & Civil Aviation Department, Government of Sikkim, along with Gujarat Tourism as State Partner and Meghalaya Tourism, Uttarakhand Tourism, Government of Uttar Pradesh, Rajasthan Tourism, Tamil Nadu Tourism and Delhi Tourism as Associate Sponsors—brought together industry leaders, policymakers and influencers to discuss India's evolving tourism sector. The event featured insightful sessions on heritage tourism, digital branding and strategic state-level initiatives. Key highlights included:

- A fireside chat with Union minister for tourism and culture Gajendra Singh Shekhawat, the event's chief guest.
- Panel discussions on state-level tourism strategies, featuring representatives from Rajasthan, Goa, Sikkim and Uttarakhand.
- Heritage tourism insights from experts like Aman Nath (Neemrana Hotels) and Sohail Hashmi (Delhi Heritage Walks).
- Social media's role in tourism branding, with influencers and content creators sharing trends in destination marketing.
- A focus on Assam's conservation and tourism initiatives, led by Padmapani Bora and conservationist Dr Purnima Devi Barman.
- A fireside chat with Mugdha Sinha, director general, ministry of tourism, on India's global appeal and evolving tourist expectations.

India Today Group Editorial Director Raj Chengappa, in his keynote address, mentioned how tourism has been a key driver of India's GDP and how it has bounced back after the pandemic. He also emphasised minister Shekhawat's innovative initiatives like Chalo India 2025, Adopt a Heritage 2.0 and the focus on sustainability in tourism. During a fireside chat, Shekhawat emphasised the importance of spiritual tourism and how the middle class is giving a fillip to tourism by travelling to popular destinations across India in droves.

The event also served as a platform to recognise excellence in tourism. The awards tracked 10 categories for which we received some 77 nominations from the states and UTs. Our market research partners MDRA then conducted on-ground and online surveys in which 4,764 participants' responses were logged to reveal the winners. In addition to this, the INDIA TODAY editorial team deliberated to arrive at a consensus on the Editor's Choice Awards across the same 10 categories. ■

REORIENTING TOURISM STRATEGY IN



SACHIN KURVE
Secretary, Tourism, and CEO, Uttarakhand Tourism Development Board

"To counter overtourism, we are promoting a new concept of creating nodes around a magnet, that is, hidden gems around a popular destination"

C.S. RAO
Principal Secretary, Tourism and Civil Aviation Department, Sikkim

"We are conserving our biodiversity. Although Sikkim occupies only 0.2 per cent of India's geographical area, it is home to 25 per cent of its biodiversity"

PECHA KUCHA–HERITAGE AND TOURISM:

AMAN NATH
Co-founder and Chairman, Neemrana Hotels

"Heritage in India is like a river. Everything flows from the past, and the ancient, medieval and modern co-exist"



MADHAVI KUCKREJA
Director, Sanatkada

"We looked at Lucknow through past and present, not only for tourists but also for its residents to discover their own city"

